

The Glorious King of Tantras, the Garland of Primordial Wisdom

Śrī Jñānamālātantrarāja · Toh 393 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ལ་ཤེས་པ་དྲེ་བའ་རིན་པོ་ལྷ་ཀྱི་རྒྱ་པོ།

Toh 393 in the Kangyur, this text is known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Jñāna Mālā Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as the Dpal ye shes phreng ba'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, rendered in English as The Glorious King of Tantras, the Garland of Primordial Wisdom. It is a tantric scripture belonging to the class of Buddhist tantras, structured as a dialogue in which a questioner addresses Vajrasattva — the Holder of the Vajra and Master of Secrets — asking about the view and conduct of the unsurpassed secret teaching. The text's opening response identifies the view with the Perfection of Wisdom, described as primordially free of conceptual elaboration, luminous within self-aware primordial wisdom, and beyond adoption or rejection, placing this tantra within a doctrinal register that emphasizes the non-dual nature of awareness. As Toh 393 in the Kangyur, it is preserved among the tantric texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon.

In the language of India: Śrī Jñāna Mālā Tantra Rāja. In the Tibetan language: The Glorious King of Tantras, the Garland of Primordial Wisdom. Homage to the glorious Vajrasattva (Skt. vajrasattva).

O Lord, Master of Secrets, Holder of the Vajra,
what, pray, is the view
of the unsurpassed secret?
And what, pray, is the conduct?
May the Supreme One explain this to me.

The Blessed One declared:

The view is the Perfection of Wisdom,
primordially free of conceptual elaboration, spontaneously accomplished,
luminous within the expanse of self-aware primordial wisdom,
not obscured by the darkness of ignorance.
The very pinnacle of wisdom, arisen to the summit,
it is the apex of all views.

In the ultimate self-aware primordial wisdom
there is nothing to adopt and nothing to discard,
neither inferior nor superior —

no meditator and nothing to meditate upon.

In the state beyond reference point, compassion,
and in the state beyond reference point, wisdom —
these two, united with mind, become one:
like space within space, that is their nature.

One who desires self-aware primordial wisdom
does not meditate on conceptuality fixated on characteristics.
One does not impute deficiency onto those of lesser capacity,
nor does one superimpose upon reality itself.

Between meditating for an aeon from the outset
and attaining self-awareness in a single instant —
even hundreds and thousands could not withstand comparison;
they cannot be measured or counted.
It is like the ocean and a wave that follows.

Meditating on what exists is not meditation.
Meditating on what does not exist is not meditation.
When existence and non-existence are of equal taste,
even without meditation, one has meditated.
Meditation and non-meditation both are absent.

When mind rests in luminosity,
it vanquishes the host of enemies — the forces of apprehender and
apprehended.

It is the place of offering for the heroes and ḍākinīs
of the ten directions together with all world-systems.

The highest practitioners have relinquished the distinction between meditative
equipoise and post-meditation.

Those of middling capacity view post-meditation as emptiness.

Those of lesser capacity view post-meditation as illusion.

The view and conduct of the lion
I declare to be the fourth.

Then the king of conducts is explained.

Conduct is of three kinds:

Samantabhadra, Bhuṣuku,

and Avadhūtī — these are the three.

Time, place, and food of conduct,
person, classification,
essential nature, measure,
skillful means, intention, and purpose —
the skilled one should apply all of these.

The buddha family, the vajra family,
the jewel family, the lotus family,
the karma family, and five conducts —
these are the conduct of Samantabhadra.

Abiding in the three vows
and holding the Three Jewels —
this is the supreme conduct of the buddhas.
Holding vajra, bell, and mudrā,
and holding to the guru — this is the conduct of the Vajra.
Pleasing samaya in the four periods of day,
and the fourfold generosity — this is the conduct of the Jewel.
Holding the three vehicles and the sacred Dharma —
this is the conduct of the Lotus of the east.
Possessing all samayas
and liberating those not yet liberated and others —
this is the conduct of the King of Horses.

Eating, sleeping, and walking —
these three should be maintained in great yoga.
Abandoning distraction through distraction itself
is the conduct of Bhuṣuku.

Wearing ornaments, tasting nectar,
relying on mudrā, and these three aspects —
this is the conduct of the Avadhūtī.
As for ornaments, there are six; as for mudrās, five.
As for nectars, there are ten; through what is impure,
this is the conduct of washing away impurity.

The place is where there is nothing blameworthy;
without distraction within or without, that is the place.

The time of learning, which vanquishes conceptual thought,
and when accomplished, the time of displaying miraculous powers.

Skillful means is being seen by others,
and being free from superimposition and denigration.

Intention is the power of the antidote,
and gain, honor, and fame
are not a food that causes pain —
at the guru's time of skillful means, receive and rely upon it well.

Food with little conceptual thought
is said to be appropriate for beginners.

The threefold classification and its distinctions
are just as stated above.

The essential nature is mind itself, free of conceptuality —
it displays purity, cessation, and emanation.
This very thing is the measure of accomplishment.

There are two kinds of purpose. From the purpose of abandoning impurity, the direct purpose has four aspects: examining whether one's own mind is stable or wavering; seeking out the special mudrā; introducing a person who can be tamed by that; and preventing the disrespect of the faithless.

With the view and conduct of the king of secret mantra,
the assembly of heroic ones (vīras) and ḍākinīs of the retinue,
having fallen into exhaustion and collapse at the appointed time,
through the meditative absorption that revives the breath,
all recovered their mindfulness once more,
and all with one voice spoke these words:

Wondrous indeed is this view
in which all things are brought to an equal taste!
Wondrous indeed is this conduct
that dispels distraction by means of distraction!
When all phenomena are equal in emptiness,
where is there viewing or not viewing?
When purity and impurity are one taste like nectar,
where is there practicing or not practicing?
Where is there empowerment and vajra-holder?
Where is there meditative equipoise and post-meditation?
In the essential nature of mind, everything —
where is there apprehended object and apprehending subject?

The Great and Terrifying One declared:
From beginningless saṃsāra,
the veil of innate obscuration
has rendered the precious mind impure.
The moon removes cataracts —
yet the eye cannot see its own dust.
The mind, failing to recognize suchness itself,
grasps at the various dualities of apprehended object and apprehending
subject.
Therefore the king of view is taught.

Through the cataract of not knowing,
the suchness of nectar is not recognized,
and one makes distinctions such as pure and impure —
therefore the king of conduct is taught.

Because of the condition of resting and the condition of distraction,
therefore the king of union is taught.

Through conditions and faculties, superior and middling,
the king of meditative equipoise and post-meditation is taught.

Through the cataract of not knowing,
in delusion one grasps at the duality of apprehended object and apprehending
subject —
therefore the king of mind is taught.

Attend diligently to this view and conduct!

Then all were filled with joy, delight, and gladness, and having made inner and
outer offerings, they dissolved into the unmanifest.

The glorious tantra known as the Garland of Primordial Wisdom, the King of
Tantras, the Union of View and Conduct, is complete.

Translated by the yoginī Candramālā and the monk Śākya Ye shes.

Translator's Notes

- The three conduct-types Bhuṣuku and Avadhūti are Sanskrit loanwords transliterated into Tibetan. Bhuṣuku is a well-known epithet associated with the mahāsiddha Śāntideva (one who eats, sleeps, and walks), and is here used as a named mode of conduct. Avadhūti refers both to the central channel and to the conduct associated with it in tantric contexts. These are retained as proper names rather than translated, as they function as technical designations within the text.

The phrase rendered as "the King of Horses" translates the Tibetan for Hayagrīva (rta yi rgyal po), and here denotes a specific mode of conduct rather than the deity per se.

The "fourth" view and conduct described as lion-like may refer to a fourfold scheme of view-conduct types within a larger classificatory framework; the exact referent of "fourth" is not made explicit in this passage alone.

- The epithet rendered "the Great and Terrifying One" translates 'jigs byed chen po, which could designate Yamāntaka or a wrathful tantric deity-figure serving as the speaker of the instruction. The text is ambiguous as to which specific deity is meant; the translation renders the epithet literally.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.